

Nigeria

 With large reserves of oil, natural gas, coal, iron ore, lead, tin, and zinc, and rich, fertile farmland, Nigeria looked set to prosper when it gained independence from Britain in 1960. However, the country's economy has experienced difficulty due to falling oil prices, ethnic conflicts, and corrupt government. After 16 years of military dictatorship, civilian rule was restored in 1999.



People

Nigerian society consists of an uneasy mix of more than 250 ethnic groups. Two-thirds of the population belongs to one of three groups – the Hausa in the north, the Ibo in the east, and the Yoruba in the west. About 57 per cent of people live in small tight-knit villages where communal life is important.

Nigerian oil has a low sulphur content and is ideal for aircraft fuel.



Oil

Nigeria's oil production, which ranks first in Africa and highly in the world, accounts for 95 per cent of all its exports. Almost totally dependent on this new industry, which began in the 1960s, Nigeria is vulnerable to changes in world oil prices.

Plantations

Agriculture employs more than 40 per cent of all Nigerian workers. Although most farmers work on small plots with simple tools, vast plantations have been established to cultivate cash crops on a commercial scale for export, using modern machinery. Crops include cotton, coffee, cocoa beans, and oil palms.



The best cloth is a mix of cotton and silk.

Cloth

Nigeria's Yoruba and Hausa peoples produce many attractive patterned textiles, hand-dyed using natural plant colours. In the Hausa town of Kano, in the north, men dye the cloth in ancient dye pits.



Abuja

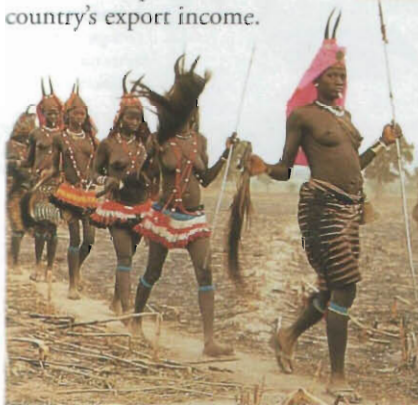
Begun in 1980, the new, purpose-built city of Abuja replaced Lagos as Nigeria's capital in 1991, because the government believed Lagos was too influenced by the Yoruba people. By the late 1990s, much of Abuja was unfinished as money ran low during construction.



Central mosque, Abuja

Benin

 A former French colony, Benin took its name from an ancient empire, in 1975, 15 years after becoming independent. It is a long, narrow country with a short coastline on the Gulf of Guinea. Most of the land is flat and forested, with a large marsh in the south. Most people live off the land, producing yams, cassava, and maize. Cotton brings in about three-quarters of the country's export income.



BENIN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Porto-Novo
AREA 110,620 sq km (42,710 sq miles)
POPULATION 6,100,000
MAIN LANGUAGES French, Fon, Bariba, Yoruba, Adja, Fulani
MAJOR RELIGIONS Traditional beliefs, Muslim, Christian
CURRENCY CFA franc



Fishing

Every year, fishermen catch about 39,000 tonnes (42,990 tons) of fish in the lagoons along the coast of Benin.

Betamaribé

One of five main ethnic groups in Benin, the Betamaribé, or Somba, live in the northwest near the Atakora Mountains. One of the first peoples to settle in Benin, they have lived free from Western influence for hundreds of years and have managed to keep many of their traditions intact.

Niger

 Although it is the largest country in West Africa, Niger is two-thirds desert. The people, who are very poor, live in the dry Sahel region, or in the southwest close to the Niger River, where they plant crops and herd animals. The country is one of the world's top producers of uranium.



NIGER FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Niamey
AREA 1,267,000 sq km (489,188 sq miles)
POPULATION 10,700,000
MAIN LANGUAGES French, Hausa, Djerma, Fulani, Tuareg, Teda
MAJOR RELIGION Muslim
CURRENCY CFA franc



Fighting the desert

The people of Niger are waging a battle against the advance of the desert into the dry Sahel where they live. They plant trees and grass in an attempt to stop the soil eroding.

Male beauty contest

Every year, in a festival known as the *gerewol*, young Wodaabé men make themselves up to try and attract a wife in an unusual beauty contest. After much dancing, the women make their choice. If a marriage proposal results, the man kidnaps the woman, and they set off into the desert for a nomadic life together.

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